

Chapter 21_2 - Beauty

After walking through the entrance hall, their view suddenly opened up. A huge circular platform filled with fresh flowers stood in the center, with a several-people-high curtain hanging behind it. Painted on it was a landscape painting so lifelike that, accompanied by the zither music, it seemed to actually move.

On the left side were stairs leading upstairs, carved with simple patterns. Unlike the usual powdery scent of ordinary pleasure houses, this place had a fresh fragrance, as if hundreds of different flowers were mixed together.

Ning Fuyi looked up toward the upstairs, seeing only shadowy lights and flames, but no one moving about.

So she coughed and said: "Is anyone there? Such a big Ruyan Tower, yet no one to receive guests?"

Her voice echoed through the building, hitting the walls and creating a faint echo. After a while, a woman finally came down from upstairs. Before seeing her, they heard her voice first - light and clear, reminiscent of birds breaking through the morning sky.

"This humble servant came late and has wronged the distinguished guests." The woman spoke sweetly, then an embroidered shoe touched the ground, and her rippling skirt cascaded down the stairs like water, trailing at her feet.

When they looked up again, Ning Fuyi's breath stopped for a moment. Though she had seen countless beauties in her previous life, such an enchanting woman was still rare. Cherry lips and hibiscus face, fragrant cheeks whiter than snow, her flowing eyes captivating - it made one's heart flutter.

Liu Wenzhu behind her must have also been dazzled by this beauty, remaining motionless for a long time.

"Why don't you quickly prepare tea for the distinguished guests!" The woman reached out and pulled out a man. He was thin and shriveled with a scar on his head, keeping his head down and saying nothing, making it impossible to see his face clearly.

"No need." Chu Qingqiu suddenly spoke, her clear and indifferent voice breaking the romantic atmosphere. She intentionally or unintentionally walked in front of Ning Fuyi, blocking her view. "Do you have any vacant private rooms?"

The woman's gaze lingered on Chu Qingqiu's face for a moment, then she smiled again, lifting her skirt with both delicate hands and said softly: "Naturally we do. Please come upstairs, distinguished guests."

With that, she gracefully went upstairs with lotus steps. Ning Fuyi and Liu Wenzhu exchanged glances and slowly followed.

This woman is strange, Ning Fuyi thought. When the woman turned around, she had looked at her face - beautiful indeed, but no longer having that captivating amazement from their earlier eye contact.

The woman led them to the third floor. When passing the second floor, Ning Fuyi briefly glanced around. Not every room had occupants - most of the private rooms had their lights extinguished, with only a few rooms brightly lit, emitting suggestive sounds as they passed.

Liu Wenzhu had never heard such things before. Her face turned completely red, and she kept her head down, pretending not to see the shadowy figures behind the doors.

Ning Fuyi had seen plenty of such scenes and was indifferent to these sounds. So she secretly glanced at Chu Qingqiu, but unfortunately, that back remained straight and her steps didn't slow down, as if unaffected.

How boring, Ning Fuyi shrugged uninterestedly and turned her attention back to the woman leading the way.

Her figure was graceful and alluring, showing no detectable aura - she didn't seem to be a cultivator, but also didn't appear to be a mortal. How strange.

"Distinguished guests, please enter." The woman stopped at a private room in the corner. She pushed open the door with her hand. The room was very bright, with lamps extending from the entrance all the way to behind a screen, and even the windows were filled with flickering candlelight. Unknown flower petals were scattered all over the floor, filling the room with rich fragrance upon entering.

Ning Fuyi wrinkled her nose. This fragrance was somewhat choking.

"Please rest here first, distinguished guests. If you need anything, this humble servant will be next door." The woman smiled charmingly and was about to leave, but was called out by Ning Fuyi.

"Wait, we have something to ask."

Before she finished speaking, the woman suddenly placed a slender finger to her lips and made a shushing sound, her flowing eyes captivating: "Young master, if you have something to discuss, come find me next door."

"Come alone." With that, she waved at the three of them and left swaying her waist, no longer paying attention no matter how much Ning Fuyi called out.

Footnotes:

1. **Zither (琴)** - Traditional Chinese stringed instrument
 2. **Lotus steps (莲步)** - A poetic way to describe a woman's graceful walking, referencing the small, bound feet that were considered beautiful in traditional Chinese culture
 3. **Private rooms (厢房)** - Individual chambers in pleasure houses for entertaining guests
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Author's Notes: This chapter continues the infiltration of Ruyan Tower, where the mysterious woman's behavior becomes increasingly suspicious, setting up the intrigue for the following chapters.